

FESTIM Fellowship Programme

Previous Fellows

Tez Orr — UKAEA (2026)



Read our interview with **Tez**, our very first FESTIM Fellow, to learn about her experience mastering FESTIM v2 at MIT.

A selective, project-based programme for experienced FESTIM users to develop advanced simulation expertise through direct collaboration with the FESTIM development team.

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What the programme is

The FESTIM Fellowship Programme is a focused, hands-on programme designed for users with prior experience who want to develop a deeper, practical understanding of the code and its capabilities.

Fellows work closely with the FESTIM development team, either remotely or in person at the MIT Plasma Science and Fusion Center (PSFC). Each Fellow brings a focused project, which serves as the main vehicle for exploring FESTIM through a real application.

The programme is centred on learning how to use FESTIM effectively and structuring simulations, leveraging advanced features, understanding how the code operates, and troubleshooting complex cases. The goal is for Fellows to return to their

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organisation as advanced FESTIM users, capable of independently developing and supporting simulation work.

Who the programme is for

The programme is intended for students, researchers, engineers, and scientists who:

- Have prior hands-on experience using FESTIM (not complete beginners)
- Are comfortable working in Python, including writing and modifying simulation scripts

FESTIM is built on top of FEniCSx, and Fellows should be prepared to engage with this layer when needed. Prior experience with FEniCSx is beneficial but not required.

We are looking for applicants who want to develop advanced capability in FESTIM and become key users within their organisation, whether in academia, research institutions, or industry.

How the programme works

Each Fellow proposes a focused project, which forms the core of their fellowship work. This project provides a practical framework for exploring FESTIM in depth through a real application.

Rather than following a fixed curriculum, the programme is structured around guided, project-based learning. Fellows work closely with the FESTIM development team, with regular interaction that includes:

- Technical discussions and working sessions
- Guidance on simulation setup, structure, and troubleshooting
- Exposure to advanced features and best practices
- Opportunities to engage with related research at the PSFC

Fellows may participate remotely or in person. The typical duration is 10 weeks, although this is flexible and can be adapted depending on the project and availability.

What you gain

- A strong, working understanding of FESTIM and how to use it effectively in real applications
- The ability to develop, structure, and manage complex simulation cases
- Confidence in troubleshooting and extending FESTIM models
- Direct collaboration with the FESTIM development team
- Connections with researchers working on related topics

What is expected

Fellows are expected to:

- Dedicate at least 25% of their time to the programme
- Actively engage with the FESTIM team and participate in discussions
- Use their project as a basis for developing deeper FESTIM expertise
- Present their work in a final seminar

By the end of the fellowship, Fellows should have achieved at least one of the following:

- Significant progress on a complex application case, resulting in a robust and reproducible simulation setup
- A contribution to the FESTIM codebase (feature, improvement, or fix)
- A validation or verification case
- Integration of FESTIM into a broader modelling framework

Funding

Fellows are supported by their home organisation or employer. The programme does not provide a stipend.

On-site participation at the MIT Plasma Science and Fusion Center (PSFC) is available for all Fellows.

For participants from academia, limited support for travel and on-site participation may be available.

Key Dates

The programme is organised in cohorts throughout the year:

Summer cohort:

- 1st April - Applications open
- 30th April - Application deadline
- 18th May - Decisions released
- 15th June* - Programme starts
- 14th August* - Programme ends

Fall cohort:

- April - Applications open
- August - Application deadline
- August - Decisions released
- October* - Programme starts
- December* - Programme ends

**Programme dates are flexible*

Apply

Interested in the FESTIM Fellowship Programme?

Apply now using the form below:

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FAQ's

How much interaction will I have with the FESTIM team?



All Fellows are welcome to join the weekly MIT-FESTIM meeting and one hour of dedicated time with the lead developers each week.



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Fellows participating on site have access to dedicated office space near the development team and are encouraged to interact on a daily basis.

Can I participate alongside a full-time role?



Where does the fellowship take place?



How long does the programme last?



Are there any costs involved?



What makes a strong application?



Can this lead to collaboration or publications?



Still have questions?

If you have further questions about the programme, or would like to discuss whether your project is a good fit before applying, please contact:

- James Dark: darkj385@mit.edu